

Chapter Five

Other People's Weather

By morning, Nora had learned that sleep was not rest when other people's grief had followed you into bed.

She woke before sunrise with her hands clenched in the sheets and the taste of sickness still faint at the back of her throat. For a moment, she did not know which sorrow had woken her.

Maya's.

Adam's.

Daniel's.

Her own.

They had tangled in the night, braided together beneath her skin. Every time she closed her eyes, another fragment waited for her.

Maya beneath the pharmacy awning, rain slipping down her cheek.

Adam staring at the ceiling, trying not to call.

Daniel bending down to take his daughter's drawing, smiling while something inside him broke.

None of it had belonged to Nora.

And yet all of it remained.

She sat up slowly.

The room was pale with early light. Her curtains moved slightly in the draft from the window she had forgotten to close. The city outside had not fully woken yet. A truck passed somewhere below, its engine low and distant. Pipes knocked in the walls. Someone's alarm rang faintly in another apartment, then stopped.

Ordinary sounds.

Nora held on to them.

Her own room.

Her own bed.

Her own hands.

She lifted one hand and turned it over, studying the lines in her palm as if they might have changed overnight.

“I am Nora Reyes,” she whispered.

The words sounded less convincing than they had in the bathroom.

She got out of bed carefully, almost politely, as if sudden movement might offend her own body into leaving again.

In the bathroom mirror, her face looked thinner than it had yesterday. That was impossible, of course. Faces did not change from one bad night. But something in her expression had sharpened. Her eyes looked older, not because they had seen more, but because they no longer knew how to stop seeing.

She brushed her teeth.

Washed her face.

Pressed both hands to the sink and waited for the world to tilt.

It did not.

The light stayed steady. The mirror gave back only herself.

Nora almost cried with gratitude.

Then guilt followed immediately, as if gratitude were a door it had been waiting behind.

She had not answered Maya’s last message.

She had not texted Adam to tell him she had made it home.

Her phone was still in the living room, abandoned on the couch where she had thrown it after returning from Daniel’s body. She found it beneath a folded blanket.

Nine missed calls.

Four from Adam.

Two from Maya.

Three from her mother.

Nora stared at the screen.

Her mother.

That name belonged to another life entirely. A life before body-jumps, before secrets, before Nora had learned that love could look like betrayal from the wrong angle.

Her mother had left a voicemail.

Nora did not play it.

She could not take another voice inside her.

Instead, she opened Adam's messages.

Did you get home?

Nora, please just send a period if you don't want to talk.

I'm trying not to panic.

Maya is worried too.

Then, at 2:41 a.m.:

I'm sorry. I know that probably makes it worse somehow. But I am.

Nora sat on the edge of the couch.

The phrase hurt because it was so Adam. Even his worry tried to make space for hers. Even his fear apologized before entering the room.

She typed:

I got home. I'm sorry I didn't text.

She paused, then added:

Something happened again.

Her thumb hovered over send.

Something happened again.

What a small, pathetic sentence for being dragged through the hidden rooms of strangers.

She sent it before she could delete it.

Adam replied almost immediately.

Can I come over?

Nora closed her eyes.

She wanted him there.

She wanted him nowhere near her.

She wanted his arms around her. She wanted never to touch him again if touching made the world open.

She wrote:

Not yet.

The reply took longer this time.

Okay.

Then:

Can you tell me what happened?

Nora looked toward the bathroom.

She remembered Daniel's large rough hands. The ache in his back. The little girl's pink coat with one missing button.

I went into someone else, she typed.

She stopped.

The sentence stared back at her.

There was no gentle way to say it. No language that could make it less impossible.

She sent it.

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Appeared again.

Then Adam wrote:

Someone else besides Maya and me?

Nora's breath caught.

He believed her.

Or he was choosing to act as if he did.

Both possibilities hurt.

Yes, she replied.

Who?

A stranger.

A long pause.

Are you safe now?

Nora looked around the apartment.

The door was locked. The windows were closed now. The morning light lay softly across the floorboards. Her body was under her control.

For the moment, yes.

She typed:

I think so.

Adam replied:

Then we need to figure this out carefully. No pressure. No forcing.
But carefully.

Nora almost smiled.

Carefully.

Of course that would be Adam's word. Even faced with the impossible, he reached for method.

Before she could answer, another message arrived.

From Maya.

Can we talk today?

Nora's throat tightened.

She opened the thread.

The last thing she had sent Maya was an apology.

I made your pain about my fear. I'm so sorry.

Maya's response had been I know.

Now this.

Can we talk today?

Nora read the message again and again until the words became less like a question and more like a hand extended across a broken floor.

She wanted to say yes.

She was terrified to say yes.

What if she jumped again while they were together? What if she slipped into Maya's body mid-sentence and felt all the pain Maya was too kind to speak aloud? What if being close to people she loved was what opened the door?

She typed:

Yes.

Then, before fear could interfere:

Anywhere you want.

Maya answered after a minute.

The old church garden? Around 3?

The old church garden.

Their place.

Nora pressed the phone to her chest.

For years, the garden behind Saint Orla's had belonged to small repairs. Exam stress. Bad dates. Maya's first serious heartbreak. Nora's panic the week Adam proposed because happiness had frightened her more than loneliness ever had.

They had sat there through so many versions of themselves.

Of course Maya would choose it.

Nora replied:

I'll be there.

Then she sat very still, holding the phone as the apartment brightened around her.

At three o'clock, the garden was quiet.

Saint Orla's stood at the end of a narrow street, old stone darkened by decades of rain. Behind it, through a black iron gate that never properly latched, was a small garden with crooked benches, overgrown rosemary, and a statue of a saint whose face had been softened by weather until she looked less holy than tired.

Nora arrived ten minutes early.

She did that when she was nervous. Arrived early. Chose the seat. Rehearsed possible sentences. Pretended preparedness could protect her from the emotional weather of other people.

She sat on the bench beneath the leafless fig tree and watched pigeons move between patches of weak sunlight.

Her hands were cold.

She had spent the day trying to build a theory.

The jumps happened during emotional overload.

Maybe.

They happened near secrets.

Maybe.

They happened when she was afraid.

Almost certainly.

But Daniel had complicated everything. She did not know him. She had no emotional bond with him. Unless the bond was not personal, but thematic. Hospital. Illness. Hidden grief. A child being protected from unbearable truth.

Maybe she had not jumped to Daniel because she knew him.

Maybe she had jumped to him because his sorrow resembled Maya's.

That possibility disturbed her.

It suggested the world was full of doors, and her fear knew how to find matching locks.

The gate creaked.

Nora looked up.

Maya stood at the entrance, one hand still on the iron, as if she had almost changed her mind.

She looked smaller somehow. Not physically. Maya had always been slender, quick-moving, full of expressive gestures. But today she seemed gathered inward. Her curls were tied back. Her face was bare of makeup. The skin beneath her eyes was shadowed.

For the first time, Nora noticed how tired Maya had been for days.

Maybe weeks.

How had she missed it?

No.

She had not missed it.

She had seen it and made it about herself.

Maya walked toward her slowly.

“Hi,” Nora said.

“Hi.”

The word fell between them and did not know where to land.

Maya sat beside her, leaving more space than she usually would.

That space was unbearable.

Nora wanted to fill it with apology, explanation, confession. She wanted to throw every truth at Maya’s feet and beg her to choose which one mattered most.

Instead, she waited.

Maya looked at the garden, not at Nora.

“My father doesn’t want many people to know,” she said.

Nora’s chest tightened.

“He thinks if people know, then it becomes real. Which is stupid because it is real. But also I understand.” Maya gave a small, humorless laugh. “He has always been like that. If he doesn’t say a thing out loud, he thinks he has delayed it.”

Nora listened.

The restraint cost her something.

“He was in remission for almost two years,” Maya continued. “Then the pain came back. Then the tests. Then the face the doctor made before he even said anything.”

Her voice thinned.

Nora's hands curled in her lap.

Do not reach unless she asks, she told herself.

Do not take over.

Do not make her manage your guilt.

Maya swallowed.

"I wanted to tell you. I did. But I knew what would happen."

Nora looked down.

"I would try to fix it," she said.

"Yes."

"I would start researching doctors."

"Yes."

"I would call you every hour."

"Probably every half hour."

Nora almost smiled. It hurt too much to become real.

Maya finally looked at her.

"And I love that about you," she said. "I do. You love like a person trying to hold a roof up during a storm. But sometimes, Nora, I don't need you to hold the roof. Sometimes I just need you to sit with me while it rains."

The sentence entered Nora quietly.

Then opened.

"I'm sorry," Nora whispered.

"I know."

"No, I need to say it properly." Nora turned toward her. "I saw pieces of something I didn't understand, and I turned them into an

accusation. I hurt you because I was afraid. I made your father's illness about whether you and Adam were keeping me out."

Maya's eyes shone, but she did not look away.

"Nora," she said softly. "How did you see pieces?"

There it was.

The question Nora had known was coming.

The garden seemed to hold its breath.

A pigeon fluttered up onto the church wall. Somewhere beyond the gate, a bicycle bell rang twice.

Nora pressed her fingers together.

"I don't know how to tell you."

"Tell me badly."

That was so Maya that Nora almost broke.

She looked at her chosen sister, at the person whose love had once entered Nora's life like light through a door she had stopped expecting anyone to open.

Then she told her.

Not all at once. Not elegantly.

She told Maya about the kitchen tilting. About standing in the rain inside Maya's body. About seeing Adam's messages. About feeling Maya's grief without understanding it. She told her about Adam's room, the memory of the hospital, the words Maya had said. Then, because stopping there would make it sound too neat, she told her about Daniel. The grocery store. The little girl. The drawing for a mother in a hospital bed.

When Nora finished, the garden had changed color. Clouds had gathered over the sun, and the stone path looked dull and silver.

Maya had not interrupted once.

That frightened Nora more than disbelief would have.

At last, Maya said, “You were inside me.”

Nora flinched.

“I didn’t choose it.”

“I know.”

“I couldn’t control anything.”

“I know.”

“It was horrible,” Nora said, then immediately hated herself. “Not because it was you. Because I had no right. Because I felt things you didn’t give me.”

Maya looked down at her hands.

For a long moment, she said nothing.

Nora forced herself not to fill the silence.

When Maya spoke, her voice was careful.

“I believe that you believe it happened.”

Nora nodded.

It was more than she deserved.

Maya continued, “I don’t know what I believe yet.”

“That’s fair.”

“But I believe you were scared. And I believe you know things you shouldn’t know.” She looked back at Nora. “And I believe you didn’t mean to hurt me.”

Nora’s eyes burned.

“But you did,” Maya said.

The words were gentle.

They still cut.

“I know.”

“I need that part to matter too.”

“It does.”

Maya’s mouth trembled. “Because I’m so tired, Nora.”

“I know.”

“No. You know now because you saw something. But I need you to hear me say it.” Maya wiped quickly beneath one eye. “I am tired. I am scared. My father is pretending to be stronger than he is. My mother keeps asking me questions with her face because she doesn’t want to ask them with words. And I cannot also be the place where your fear comes to prove itself.”

Nora bowed her head.

There it was.

The consequence.

Not supernatural.

Not impossible.

Human.

“I don’t know how to stop,” Nora said.

“Stop what?”

“Being afraid that people will leave.”

Maya’s expression softened, but she did not rush to comfort her.

That restraint, Nora realized, was Maya protecting herself.

“I know,” Maya said.

Nora laughed once, brokenly. “Everyone knows.”

“Because we love you.”

The answer was immediate.

Firm.

Nora looked at her.

Maya's face was wet now, but steady.

"Nora, loving you is not the problem," she said. "Being suspected by you is."

The sentence landed with such clean precision that Nora could not defend against it.

She did not try.

For a while, they sat in silence.

The garden moved gently around them. Leaves shifted. A car passed beyond the wall. The old saint watched them with her weather-softened face.

Then Maya reached into her bag and took out a folded paper.

"I brought something," she said.

Nora watched as she opened it.

It was a photocopy of a hospital appointment schedule. Dates. Times. Department names. A doctor's name printed in black.

"My father starts treatment again next week," Maya said. "I'm not giving this to you so you can take over."

Nora nodded quickly. "Okay."

"I'm giving it to you because I don't want to hide anymore. Not from you. But there have to be rules."

"Rules," Nora repeated.

"Yes." Maya's voice strengthened slightly. "You can ask how I am. You can ask what I need. You can come with me if I invite you. You cannot call doctors. You cannot make plans with my mother behind my back. You cannot turn every quiet moment into evidence that I'm keeping something from you."

Nora took the words in like medicine.

Bitter.

Necessary.

“I can do that,” she said.

Maya studied her.

“I want to believe you.”

“I know.”

“No, don’t just say that.” Maya’s voice cracked. “I need you to understand that I want to believe you, but I’m scared too now.”

Nora stilled.

Maya folded the paper again, carefully, as if the creases mattered.

“I used to feel safe telling you anything,” she said. “Now I’m scared that if I say the wrong thing, you’ll turn it into proof of something.”

Nora felt the shame rise.

She wanted to explain that she had been terrified. That the jumps had broken something open in her. That suspicion had not felt like a choice when every fragment arrived sharpened by panic.

But explanations could become another way of asking the wounded person to carry the wounder.

So she said, “I understand.”

Maya looked tired again.

But not unreachable.

That was something.

The clouds shifted, and sunlight returned briefly, pale and almost apologetic.

Maya handed her the folded schedule.

Nora did not take it immediately.

“Are you sure?” she asked.

A small change passed across Maya’s face.

Surprise.

Then relief.

“Yes,” Maya said. “I’m sure.”

Nora took the paper.

It felt heavier than it should have.

Her phone buzzed in her coat pocket.

Both women looked down.

Nora did not move.

Maya watched her.

Then Nora took out the phone and turned the screen toward her.

Adam.

Maya’s expression flickered.

“You can answer,” she said.

Nora shook her head. “Not while I’m with you.”

The phone buzzed again.

Nora declined the call.

It was a small thing.

But Maya saw it.

For the first time that afternoon, some of the tension in her shoulders eased.

They sat for another hour.

They did not fix everything. There was no dramatic forgiveness, no clean return to what they had been before. Maya told Nora about her father in pieces. Nora listened. Sometimes she asked a careful question. Sometimes she said nothing at all.

Once, Maya cried.

Nora did not pull her into an embrace immediately.

She waited.

Then Maya leaned sideways, just slightly, her shoulder touching Nora's.

Permission.

Nora put an arm around her.

Maya let herself be held.

For a few minutes, the world was almost simple.

But when Nora closed her eyes, she felt the dangerous softness of Maya beside her, the old closeness, the emotional nearness that had preceded the first jump.

Fear stirred.

No.

Please no.

She opened her eyes quickly.

The garden remained.

Maya remained herself.

Nora remained Nora.

But across the street, beyond the iron gate, a woman stood on the sidewalk with one hand pressed to her chest.

Nora noticed her because the woman was staring at the church doors without moving.

She was middle-aged, with a gray coat buttoned wrong and a grocery bag hanging from one wrist. Her face had the stunned, emptied look of someone who had just received news and not yet become the person who knew it.

Nora's breath slowed.

A pressure touched the back of her eyes.

Not now.

The woman across the street closed her eyes.

Nora gripped the edge of the bench.

"Nora?" Maya asked.

"I'm okay," Nora said.

But she was not.

The pressure deepened.

The garden blurred at the edges.

Maya turned toward her fully. "Nora?"

The woman across the street dropped her grocery bag. Apples rolled across the pavement.

Nora stood.

Or tried to.

The world shifted.

For one terrifying second, she felt two griefs at once: Maya's beside her, and the stranger's across the street, opening like a black door.

"Nora!" Maya grabbed her wrist.

The contact pulled her back halfway.

The garden snapped into focus.

Then blurred again.

Nora looked at Maya, who was holding her now with both hands, fear bright in her face.

“Don’t let go,” Nora whispered.

“I won’t.”

But the pressure behind Nora’s eyes became a tide.

The church bells began to ring.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

Each sound broke the world further.

Maya’s hands were warm around her wrists.

The stranger’s grief was cold and enormous.

Nora tried to stay.

She tried with everything in her.

But the last thing she saw was Maya’s face, terrified not of being misunderstood now, but of losing Nora to something neither of them could name.

Then the garden vanished.

And Nora fell into another life.